A day before, addressing a gathering of students in Bhuj in Kutch, Narendra Modi had boasted, ‘Tomorrow the country will compare my speech with that of the prime minister. When we unfurl the tricolour, the message will also go to Lal Qila. The nation will want to know what was said there and what is said here.’ Modi had thrown an unprecedented challenge. He may only have been the chief minister of Gujarat, he still hadn’t been formally made the BJP’s prime ministerial candidate, but he was already acting and talking like one. It was typical Modi—cocky and arrogant, but also self-confident and daring.

Next morning, he lived up to his promise. A little after 9 a.m., soon after the prime minister’s speech was over, Modi got up to speak in Bhuj. For almost an hour, he spoke almost as if he was participating in a public debate with the prime minister and the Government of India. This wasn’t just an Independence Day address—this was an election speech. The audience wasn’t Gujarat but the people of the country. He even had a mock Red Fort erected on the podium.

If the prime minister had sounded a bit mournful, like the Delhi weather that day, Modi exuded aggression in a direct attack on the Congress leadership. Sample this: ‘You unfurled the tricolour so many times, Mr Prime Minister, but you raise the same issues that Pandit Nehru raised sixty years ago!’; ‘You are so caught up in the bhakti of one family, you have forgotten all other issues’; ‘The nation must be freed from nepotism, from the arrogance of those in power’; ‘The country is in poverty and fed up of corruption. People want a new *soch* [thinking].’ A police officer standing next to Modi fainted in the heat while the speech was on, but the chief minister just rolled on. Again, with no prepared text or notes.

India had never seen anything quite like it—a ceremonial Independence Day occasion, which is meant to exchange pleasantries, had been converted into an open, hostile bid for power. Predictably, the Congress was livid. Their spokespersons were all over television channels, accusing Modi of betraying the spirit and traditions of 15 August.

I telephoned Modi a few days later and asked him whether he had any regrets over confronting the prime minister on Independence Day. His